



RELOCATION GUIDE • NEW ZEALAND

Palmerston North

Tē Papaioea

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Palmerston North.

Ethicare Resourcing

September 2026 • ethicareresourcing.com

Nau mai ki Tē Papaioea

Welcome to Palmerston North

Moving country is a bold thing to do, and it is rarely only about the job. This guide is here to make the practical parts easier: where people live, what the work is like, how you would get around, and what an ordinary week might actually feel like.

It is written by people who arrange these moves for a living, which means two things. We know the questions that arrive at two in the morning. And we would rather tell you the awkward parts now than have you find them in month three.

Nothing in here is a pitch. If Palmerston North turns out to be the wrong answer for you, this guide should help you work that out just as quickly – and that is a good outcome, not a failed one.

Whatever you decide, you are welcome to ask us anything at all.

Sophie

FOUNDER, ETHICARE RESOURCING

What's inside

01 **Welcome to Palmerston North**

02 **Why Palmerston North**

03 **Palmerston North at a glance**

04 **Healthcare in Palmerston North**

05 **Where clinicians live**

06 **Cost of living**

07 **Getting around**

08 **Food, shopping & the everyday**

09 **River, ranges & the coast**

This is the short version. Every section here has a fuller chapter on our website, kept up to date — so if something looks time-sensitive, check there. We have left rents, salaries and other figures out on purpose: a number that was right when this was written would be quietly wrong by the time you read it, and a PDF cannot be corrected once it is sent. Those live on the site instead.



01

TE PAPAIOEA

Welcome to Palmerston North

Nau mai, haere mai ki Te Papaioea.

~90,000

People in the city, with around a quarter of a million across the wider Manawatū-Whanganui region.

~1 HR 50

To Wellington by road, or a little under two hours on the commuter train. Close enough for a concert, far enough to be a different life.

~10 MIN

A typical commute, from most of the city to the hospital. Fifteen if you take it slowly.



Dressed for a celebration organised by the Kerala Society of Manawatū. Left, Neethu's daughter; Neethu was placed by Ethicare as an anaesthetic technician at Palmerston North Hospital.

The city people underestimate

Palmerston North sits in the middle of the Manawatū plain, an hour and a half or so north of Wellington, with the Tararua and Ruahine ranges rising to the east and thirty kilometres of dune coast to the west. It is a city of around ninety thousand people built almost entirely on the flat, which makes it the easiest place in New Zealand to cycle and one of the easiest to park.

Two things shape it. The first is Massey University, whose main campus sits just south of the river and gives the city a young, international, research-driven character that a place this size would not otherwise have. The second is the hospital – the base hospital for the wider region, and one of a small number of centres in the country delivering radiation oncology.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Palmerston North specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally – visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools – lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Palmerston North](#) for the full case – and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Healthcare here](#), because the clinical offer in this city is more interesting than its size suggests.



02

THE CASE FOR PALMY

Why Palmerston North

Nobody arrives in New Zealand with Palmerston North at the top of their list. It is the city clinicians end up choosing on the arithmetic, and then stay in for reasons that have nothing to do with arithmetic at all.

MONDAY TO FRIDAY

Ten to fifteen minutes to work, or twenty on the bike along the river path. Parking is easy. You will be home before you would have left the car park in a larger city.

AFTER WORK

The Esplanade gardens, the He Ara Kotahi river loop, or a swim. In term time there is live music and student-priced food most nights of the week.

SATURDAY

The farmers' market in the morning, then either the ranges or the coast — both within half an hour, in opposite directions.

Anu and her husband in Palmerston North. Anu was placed by Ethicare as an anaesthetic technician at Palmerston North Hospital, and is part of a close circle of colleagues there.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. A nurse, radiation therapist, physiotherapist or sonographer on a given step earns exactly the same here as in Auckland or Tauranga. What changes is what the money buys.

Add to that a commute measured in single-figure minutes, free or cheap parking, and a city small enough that you are never more than twenty minutes from anything. The compounding effect on your life is larger than people expect: you get hours back every week, and you spend materially less to live better.

The six things people ask us

More than you would expect, and this is the point most people miss. Palmerston North is a base hospital serving a large region, and it delivers radiation oncology – something only a handful of centres in New Zealand do. For medical imaging, radiation therapy and oncology-adjacent professions that makes it a genuinely significant place to work. [Healthcare here](#) sets out the detail.

The honest answer: it depends what you need. The university keeps a real cultural and sporting calendar going, the food scene is better than the city's reputation, and the outdoors is immediate. But it is not Wellington. If you want a dense cultural life within walking distance, this is not that, and Wellington is ninety minutes away for the nights when you want it.

When we'd point you elsewhere

Palmy suits clinicians doing the maths – the gap between salary and costs is wider here than almost anywhere in the North Island, and the ten-minute commute quietly returns you a working week every year. Nobody moves for the skyline; plenty stay for the life.



03

PLAIN, RANGES AND COAST

Palmerston North at a glance

A flat city in the middle of a river plain, with a mountain range twenty-five minutes east and a wild dune coast half an hour west. The geography is the whole explanation: for the wind, for the cycling, and for how easy everything is to reach.

ACROSS THE CITY

10–15 minutes, corner to corner, at any hour.

→ FEILDING

20 minutes north. An award-winning country town with a famous Friday market.

→ THE COAST

30 minutes west to Himatangi or Foxton Beach — dunes, driftwood and black sand.

The ranges at the edge of the plain, twenty-five minutes from town

The shape of the place

The Manawatū River comes down through the ranges and out across a wide alluvial plain to the Tasman. Palmerston North sits on that plain, just south of the river, laid out on a grid around a central square. There are almost no hills in the city; the only meaningful rise is on the southern edge towards Aokautere and Massey.

East, the Tararua and Ruahine ranges wall off the Wairarapa and Hawke's Bay, split by the Manawatū Gorge — Te Āpiti. West, the plain runs out through Feilding and Foxton to a thirty-kilometre stretch of dunes and black-sand surf beach. North lie farmland and the Rangitīkei; south, Horowhenua and the road to Wellington.

The four seasons

Indicative daytime highs. Nights are considerably cooler than the northern regions, and winter frosts are normal rather than notable.

The wind is the local signature. The Manawatū sits in a gap between two mountain ranges, which funnels the prevailing westerly straight across the plain. That is why there is a large wind farm on the hills above the gorge, and it is why the region is one of the windiest in the country. In practice: most days a breeze, a few days a year strong. People arriving from Wellington think it is calm.

Words you'll hear

A flat, green, temperate city with genuine seasons, wind, and mountains and coast half an hour apart in opposite directions. The climate asks for a warm house rather than a dry one. What makes the place work is that nothing is far away – [Where clinicians live](#) is the next practical read.

Healthcare in Palmerston North

This is the chapter that changes people's minds about Palmerston North. The clinical offer here is materially larger than the size of the city would lead you to expect, and for some professions it is one of the more interesting places in the country to work.

BROAD SCOPE

Outside the tertiary centres you carry a wider caseload and make more of the decisions yourself. Clinicians who want to be capable generalists do well here.

A LARGE RURAL CATCHMENT

The service reaches into Tararua, Horowhenua and the Rangitikei. Distance, access and rural health inequity are part of the daily picture.

AN ACADEMIC EDGE

A large university in the same city, with health sciences, nursing and research activity. Useful if teaching, research or postgraduate study matters to you.

The shape of the service

Public hospital and specialist services are delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. The hospital in Palmerston North is the base hospital for a large catchment — the Manawatū, Horowhenua, Tararua and out towards the Kāpiti coast — carrying acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, maternity, paediatrics, intensive care, imaging and outpatient services.

Around it sit community and district services, primary care, iwi and Māori health providers, and rural services reaching into some genuinely remote country east of the ranges. Complex and highly specialised work — neurosurgery, cardiothoracics, the most complex paediatrics — is referred south to Wellington, under two hours away.

Working with te ao Māori

This is the rohe of Rangitāne o Manawatū, with Ngāti Kahungunu, Muaūpoko, Ngāti Raukawa and others across the wider catchment. Iwi-led health providers are an established part of care delivery, particularly in Tararua and Horowhenua where deprivation and distance compound.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau in the room and involved in decisions. You are not expected to arrive fluent – you are expected to try. The national chapter [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured – ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system – lives in [How the health system works](#).



05

TWELVE PLACES COMPARED

Where clinicians live

In most cities this chapter is about balancing commute against cost. In Palmerston North the commute is ten minutes from everywhere, so you get to choose on something better: what you actually want your street to feel like.

HOKOWHITU

The city's most sought-after address, and deservedly. Leafy streets by the river and the Esplanade, established homes, mature trees, well-regarded schools. Ten minutes to the hospital, and a walk to the water.

WEST END & FITZROY

Character villas and bungalows close to the city centre, walkable to The Square and to work. Popular with clinicians who want to leave the car at home.

MILSON

Solid, friendly, good-value family housing to the north, well served by schools and parks. A lot of people's first house here.

The nearby towns

Most clinicians we move here rent for six months and then buy, which is a shorter runway than in most cities — because the market is affordable enough that you do not need to save for years first. How renting works — the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards — is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#).



06

WHERE THE MONEY GOES FURTHER

Cost of living

In most of this collection the cost chapter is where we manage expectations. Here it is the argument. Palmerston North has the best housing value of any North Island city with a base hospital, and on a clinical salary that changes what your life looks like.

HOKOWHITU & AOKAUTERE

The premium end of a modest market. Expect to pay the top of the local range for an established riverside or hillside home — still well below the national city average.

WEST END, FITZROY & FITZHERBERT

Mid-range, close in, walkable. Character housing, which means checking the insulation.

MILSON, AWAPUNI, TAKARO, TERRACE END

The best value inside the city. Ordinary, comfortable family suburbs at prices that surprise people arriving from anywhere larger.

Why there are no prices on this page

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Palmerston North against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The thing that matters most

Clinical pay is national. You arrive on the same salary you would earn in Auckland, Tauranga or Wellington, into a housing market that costs a fraction of theirs. That is the entire proposition, and it is unusually clean.

Concretely: a three or four-bedroom family home with a garden, in an established suburb, in a decent school zone, ten minutes from the hospital, is an ordinary purchase on one clinical income here. In Tauranga that is difficult on two. In Auckland it is out of reach for most people we place. If home ownership is part of why you are moving countries, this city does it faster than anywhere else in the North Island.

Renting, by area

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent takes just over half — the smallest absolute rent line of any North Island city with a base hospital.

Indicative prices that change over time. Note the power line — it is higher here than in the warm north, and that is the one place this city costs you more.

Getting around

This is the shortest chapter in the guide, and that is the point. Palmerston North is flat, compact and laid out on a grid. There is no traffic problem to explain, no bridge to queue for, and no suburb from which work is a slog.

CITY BUSES

A regional network across the city and out to Feilding and Ashhurst, paid for with a Bee Card — the same card used across the Manawatū, Waikato and Bay of Plenty. Useful, cheap, and modest in frequency.

THE COMMUTER TRAIN

A weekday service between Palmerston North and Wellington. Slower than driving but far more civilised, and it makes the occasional day in the capital genuinely easy.

LONG-DISTANCE RAIL

The main trunk line runs through the city, so the scenic long-distance service stops here on its way between Auckland and Wellington.

The commute

Ten to fifteen minutes by car from essentially anywhere in the city, at any hour. There is a mild thickening around school pick-up and on the northern approaches, and that is the whole story. Parking at the hospital and in town is straightforward and cheap or free.

If you are arriving from London, Manchester, Johannesburg, Dubai or Auckland, this is the change that will surprise you most. Clinicians tell us they get an hour or more back every day, and that the hour is worth more than they expected.

Cycling, properly

Palmerston North has the best case for everyday cycling of any city we write about. It is almost entirely flat, distances are short, and there is a real network of shared paths — including **He Ara Kotahi**, the riverside path and bridge linking the city to the south bank and the university.

The practical consequence: a genuine proportion of the city cycles to work as a matter of course, not as a statement. An e-bike is barely necessary here, though the wind is the one argument for having one. It is also a very good city to teach children to ride in.

Distances worth knowing

Times on a good run. The road east over the ranges is the one to check in bad weather.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).



08

A STUDENT CITY EATS WELL

Food, shopping & the everyday

The city's food reputation lags well behind the reality, and the reason is the university. Twenty thousand students and a research community make a market for good, cheap, varied food that a city of ninety thousand would not otherwise support.

GEORGE STREET

The city's dining lane — a good strip of small restaurants and bars a minute from The Square, and the answer when someone asks where to go.

BROADWAY AVENUE & THE SQUARE

Cafés, bakeries and bistros around the green centre. The everyday lunch and coffee territory.

STUDENT VALUE

Asian, Indian, Middle Eastern and Pacific food at prices that reflect who eats it. Some of the best-value eating in New Zealand.

Onam at home in Palmerston North: Rezon and friends from the hospital, with their families, around a sadya on banana leaves. [Read their story →](#)

Markets and what the region grows

The Manawatū is a farming plain, and the food culture follows from it. The **Saturday farmers' market** in the city is the weekend fixture – produce, meat, bread, cheese and coffee, and half the neighbourhood.

Twenty minutes north, **Feilding** is a proper country town with a famous Friday market and working saleyards. It is worth going once as an outing and then repeatedly for the food. Between the two you can eat almost entirely from within thirty kilometres.

Groceries and the practical stuff

All the main supermarket chains, plus large-format retail on the northern edge of the city. Food in New Zealand is expensive by British or Australian standards – that is national rather than local, and it is the adjustment people mention most.

For specialist ingredients, the student population is your ally: there are Asian, Indian and halal grocers here well out of proportion to the city's size, and a reasonable range beyond that. It is not Auckland, so if a particular cuisine is central to how your family eats, check before you commit – the national chapter [Finding your feet & your people](#) covers where to look and which communities are established here.



09

WEEKENDS HERE

River, ranges & the coast

*The gift of a flat city in the middle of an island:
mountains twenty-five minutes one way, coast half an
hour the other, a river through the middle, and half the
North Island inside a three-hour drive.*

**TE ĀPITI / MANAWATŪ
GORGE**

Twenty-five minutes east. Walking tracks through native bush along the gorge, a ridgeline route, and a lookout among the wind turbines. The region's signature day out.

THE TARARUA RANGE

Serious tramping country right on the doorstep — huts, tops and weather that demands respect. Some of the best training ground in the country.

**THE RUAHINE &
RANGIWĀHIA**

North-east of the city, with the Rangiwhāhia Track and its swing bridge — a beautiful half-day into bush and open tops.

Neethu and her husband out for the day. Neethu was placed by Ethicare as an anaesthetic technician at Palmerston North Hospital.

The river, from your door

The Manawatū runs along the southern edge of the city, and the path network along it is the thing residents use most. **He Ara Kotahi** – the shared path and its bridge – links the city to the south bank, the university and a long, flat, scenic loop that works equally well for a run, a ride or a pram.

Next to it, the **Victoria Esplanade**: riverside gardens, a rose collection, an aviary, a playground and a miniature railway. Unfashionable and entirely lovely, and if you arrive with children it will become a fixture within a fortnight.

The coast

Half an hour west and you are in a different landscape: thirty kilometres of dunes, marram grass, driftwood and black sand, with the Tasman rolling in. Himatangi Beach, Foxton Beach and the mouths of the rivers are wild rather than pretty – big skies, long horizons and very few people.

It is not a swimming-beach culture in the way the Bay of Plenty is; the surf is heavy and the water is cooler. What it is instead is genuinely dramatic, and empty, and twenty minutes closer than most people expect.

Useful links

The region's official visitor site: events, food, trails and things to do.

COUNCIL

Palmerston North City Council ↗

Local services, libraries, pools, parks and community programmes.

OUTDOORS

Department of Conservation ↗

Tracks, huts and reserves across the Tararua and Ruahine ranges.

CULTURE

Te Manawa ↗

The city's museum, art gallery and science centre, in one building.

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Palmerston North. Everything national – visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori – lives in [Moving to New Zealand](#). When you'd like to talk it through, [we're here](#), with no pressure and no pipeline.

Where to go next

You do not need a moving date, a decision or a CV to talk to us. If Palmerston North is on your list, tell us what you do and what you are weighing up, and we will be straight with you about whether we can help.

Everything on our website is free to read whether or not you ever work with us.

The full Palmerston North guide — ethicareresourcing.com/destinations/palmerston-north-new-zealand

Registration pathway checker — ethicareresourcing.com/pathway-checker

What reaches your bank account — ethicareresourcing.com/take-home-pay

What the move itself costs — ethicareresourcing.com/cost-calculator

Talk to us — hello@ethicareresourcing.com
